initiated, even as the world was grappling with the first wave of the Covid pandemic, clearly pointed to the fact that it had to have had 'blessings' right from the very top.

We immediately launched Op Snow Leopard, the induction of our reserve formations, which were in any case ready to move. The only difference was that they were moved by air in Air Force C-17s, which had been acquired precisely for such large-scale strategic moves. There was full synergy between the DG Air Ops, Air Marshal BR Krishna and our DGMO, Lt Gen Paramjit Singh Sangha.[15] The speed of our response and the manner in which we are able to induct forces, including armour and artillery, was copybook and fully validated our Operational Air Move Plans (OAMP), so painstakingly made and refined over the years. All formations were fully equipped with adequate cold-weather clothing and all other equipment necessary for deployment and prolonged stay in inhospitable high-altitude areas. On disembarking, all formations were moved closer to their deployment areas, with adequate time to carry out acclimatization. Full credit must go to the respective Operations and Operational Logistics Branches, particularly of the Air Force. Aircraft were ready and waiting on the tarmac, whether at Delhi or Chandigarh as per the requirements.

While this induction was underway, or more likely on account of the speed of our response, it was the PLA who first suggested that we should have Corps Commander-level meetings to defuse the situation. This would be between their Commander of the South Xinjiang Military Region (SXMR), Maj Gen Liu Lin, and our 14 Corps Commander, Lt Gen Harinder Singh. Although the rank on the PLA side appears one level lower, it was functionally equivalent, and the CSG cleared this proposal.[16] Accordingly, it was decided to hold the first Senior Highest Military Commander Level

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation